

GITCRAFT DESIGNCRAFT · GAME DESIGN BRIEF

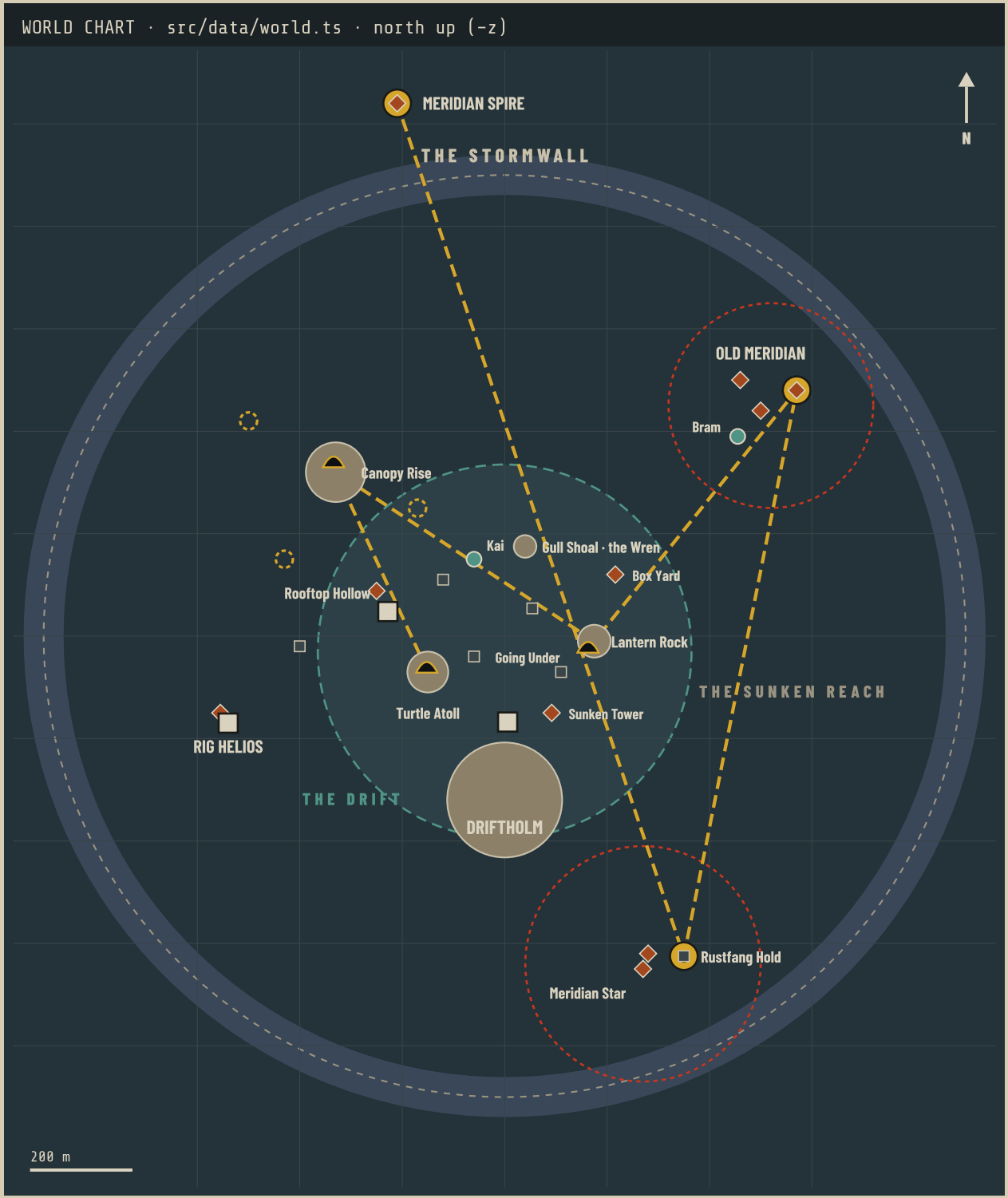
TIDEBREAKERS

Making TIDEBREAKERS one living pirate adventure.

Fourteen characters developed, a 13-step first voyage redesigned, and a dinghy-to-pirate-ship ladder. Islands, ports, caves and treasure are tied into one legend. Every proposal comes in Conservative, Ambitious and Wild Card tiers, with its gameplay impact, implementation and tradeoffs.

v1.0 · 2026-11-05 · assessed at commit 5766ca5
Authoritative brief for the next implementation pass

PREVIEW · NOT SAVED



03 · The World

One map

- Settlement with services (3)
- Salvage site (10)
- Outpost, set dressing only (6)
- Walkable island (5)
- Castaway: crew to rescue (2)
- Rustfang raider zone (2)
- PROPOSED Redfinch Line, maps 1-6
- PROPOSED north-west discovery (3)
- PROPOSED sea-cave mouth (3)

THREE REGIONS, THREE HULLS

The Drift

Silted shallows, home and the first legend clues. Reached in the Patchwork Skiff.

`Driftholm · Turtle Atoll · Lantern Rock · Gull Shoal (the Wren) · Sunken Tower · Box Yard · Rooftop Hollow`

The Sunken Reach

Open swell over drowned cities, with trade and raiders. Needs the Scrap Trimaran.

`Old Meridian · Rig Helios · Canopy Rise · Rustfang Graveyard & Hold`

The Stormwall

A storm that never ends, with the Meridian Spire inside it. Needs the Ironwake.

`Meridian Spire › the Last Summit chart`

Positions are the real coordinates from world.ts. Dashed gold marks the proposed Redfinch Line: the six treasure maps in story order.



stand-in: generic townsfolk

Cartographer · Charts & Rumours · she/her

Old Wren

Home: Driftholm

Model: generic tb_npc_elder (lantern, long white hair)

EXISTS: Reads map fragments and tells 4 rumours (ui.ts:977-980), plus a fragment hint and an 'edge of the map' line. She is the best-written NPC, at about 8 lines.

WANT

Someone to finish Redfinch's voyage, and to be forgiven for not going with him.

WOUND

She was the Wren's navigator. The boat was named for her. She stayed ashore the night they sailed for the Stormwall.

VOICE

Riddles that turn out to be instructions. Knows more than she says, and says so.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** Sends you to Turtle Atoll for the bottle: the reason for the First Voyage (Ambitious).
2 **Drift:** Holding both halves of Redfinch's Chart: 'That's my hand on the left half, captain.'
3 **Stormwall:** The Chart of the Last Summit is in her handwriting. She asks to come aboard for the final voyage (new berth event).

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

before the First Voyage: "A bottle washed up on Turtle, the gulls say. Bring me what's inside, and don't read it first. Read it first."

Redfinch map complete: "That's my hand on the left half. I drew it for him. I didn't go."

summit chart brought home: "He made it. The stubborn fool made it."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Wren's Rumour Board: three rumours at a time, each pinnable to the chart as an optional lead. This is the main source of player-chosen goals (see Agency).



art need: unique model

Paint, Sails & Curios · she/her

Odessa Brightly

Home: Driftholm (Brightly's Curios)

Model: none (no NPC model assigned)

EXISTS: Sells paint, sails and flags. 2 lines (ui.ts:791, :999).

WANT

To sew a flag worth being afraid of: the Tidebreaker colours.

WOUND

Lost her own boat to vanity: she painted it gold and Rustfang saw it from three miles away.

VOICE

Theatrical, affectionate insults, calls everyone 'darling'.

ARC · THREE BEATS

1 **Drift:** First cosmetic. 'A boat should look like its captain. Yours looks... damp.'
2 **Reach:** Wants Helios flare-red dye (a Rig Helios contract) and unlocks the Helios Sunburst flag sooner.
3 **Stormwall:** Through the Wall, she sews the Tidebreaker colours, a unique flag shown on every vessel you own.

NEW LINES BY TRIGGER

Renown rank up: "They're talking about you on the pier, darling. Let's give them something to point at."

legendary cosmetic earned: "Stormbreaker grey. Finally, a captain I can dress."

GAMEPLAY HOOK

Odessa's Colours: the flag cosmetic gains an emblem layer (Grinning Sun, tidecurl, compass rose, from creative/branding) unlocked by Renown.

09 · GAMEPLAY EXAMPLE · THE WREN'S BOTTLE (AMBITIOUS VOYAGE)

Minutes 0–12

0:00 Title orbit over Driftholm. SET SAIL. Old Wren at the pier, lantern up: 'A bottle washed up on Turtle…'

> character · motivation

0:40 Drag the wheel; cast off north. Gulls. A drifting algae mat: 'Ease off to pick through it.' 2 Algae Mats.

> steer · flotsam

1:30 Turtle Atoll rises, a dead coral ring. ANCHOR prompts in the turquoise. GO ASHORE.

> anchor · ashore

2:30 A glint on the south beach: the bottle. The map scrap opens itself: 'Stand between the grinning skull and the two sisters…'

> explore · clue

4:00 Shovel rings loose sand. The chest: doubloons, a pearl, the Turtle Idol. The lid is scratched 'R.F.'

> dig · legend seed

5:30 Back aboard. The radar blips: a raft with a ragged flag. Kai waves both arms. RESCUE (+60 s) or press on?

> choice 1

7:00 The Sunken Tower looms. SALVAGE. The winch: three green-zone hits. Transistor Radio and scrap.

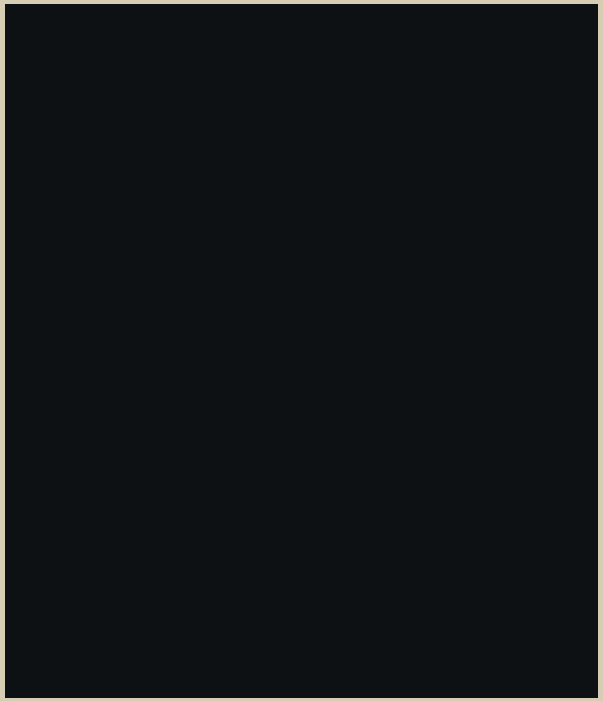
> salvage · winch

9:00 Driftholm. Pip: 'Ooh!' Sell the idol. Marlo lays out three parts: sail, rudder or crate. Pick one.

> trade · choice 2

11:00 Wren turns the lid over: 'R.F. Redfinch. So he did come this way.' The Log opens on two leads.

> legend · agency



WHAT THIS PROVES

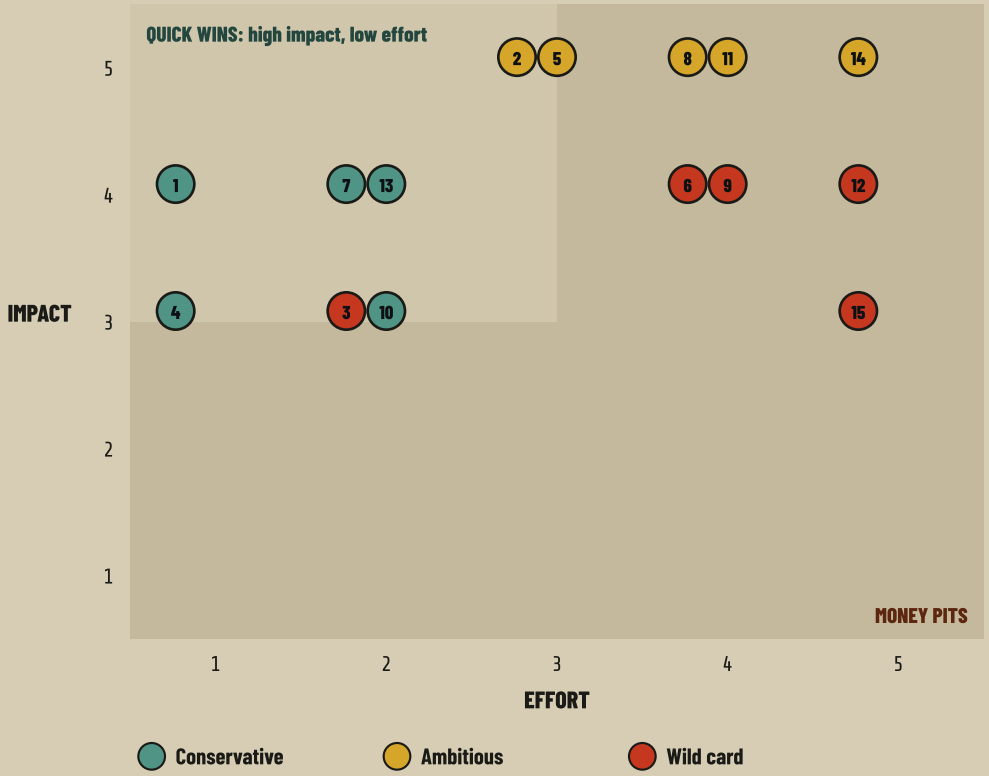
Every row is a real system in the build (sail, flotsam, anchor, dig, salvage, castaway, trade, upgrade, raiders) or a proposal from this bible (contracts, the Green Choice, Renown, Mara's Survey, arcs).

BEATS TOUCHED

agency · anchor · ashore · character · choice 1 · choice 2 · clue · dig · explore · flotsam · legend · legend seed · motivation · salvage · steer · trade · winch

10 · ROADMAP

Fifteen proposals, ranked



#	AREA	PROPOSAL	PLAN
1	**Characters** C	Voices for all 14 (≥ 6 lines each) `impact 4 · effort 1 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
2	**Characters** A	Three-beat arcs + Vik/Juno choice `impact 5 · effort 3 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
3	**Characters** W	Old Wren joins the final voyage `impact 3 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 3**
4	**First Voyage** C	Tighten 13 › 8 `impact 3 · effort 1 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
5	**First Voyage** A	The Wren's Bottle `impact 5 · effort 3 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
6	**First Voyage** W	Swamped cold open `impact 4 · effort 4 · risk high`	**Prototype**
7	**Agency** C	Two Roads & Rumour Pins `impact 4 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
8	**Agency** A	Contracts, Renown, Green Choice `impact 5 · effort 4 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
9	**Agency** W	Letters of Marque `impact 4 · effort 4 · risk high`	**Prototype**
10	**Progression** C	Refit stages, Renown, Name her `impact 3 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
11	**Progression** A	The Salt Brig `impact 5 · effort 4 · risk med`	**Phase 2 · rec.**
12	**Progression** W	Take Her (Ironwake heist) `impact 4 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Prototype**
13	**Places** C	Cave mouths + Redfinch maps 3 `impact 4 · effort 2 · risk low`	**Phase 1**
14	**Places** A	Redfinch Line 4–5 + interiors `impact 5 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Phase 2 (maps) · rec.**
15	**Places** W	Tide caves `impact 3 · effort 5 · risk high`	**Prototype**